

# A poster makes a promise

Multimedia 12 • visual communication, colour and typography



Decide what the viewer should notice, feel and understand.

Then show which choices create that result.

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**TRY • 2 MIN** Without discussing first, write the first two things you noticed. Compare responses.

# Audience, purpose and viewing context

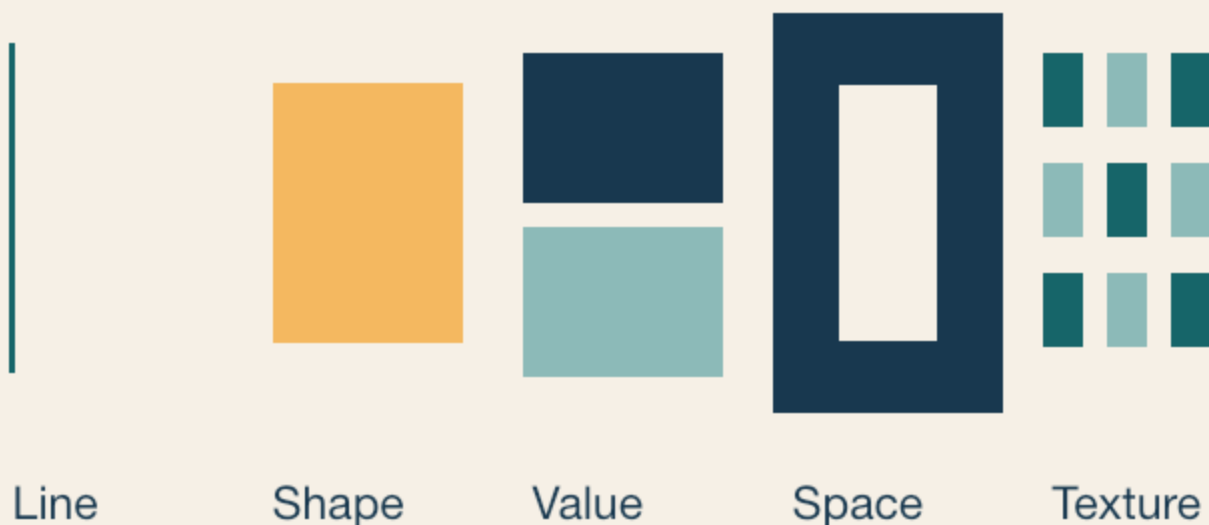
A successful choice answers a particular communication problem.

|       |                   |                                                     |
|-------|-------------------|-----------------------------------------------------|
| WHO   | Specific audience | Audience: who encounters the image?                 |
| WHY   | Message / action  | Purpose: what should they understand or do?         |
| WHERE | Viewing context   | Context: phone, corridor print or cinema billboard? |

**TRY · 2 MIN** For a school screening, write one sentence naming audience, purpose and viewing context.

# Elements and principles

Elements are ingredients; principles describe their relationships.



Line, shape, form, space, colour, value and texture.

Balance, emphasis, movement, proportion, rhythm and unity.

Graphic layouts also use contrast, alignment and proximity.

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**TRY • 2 MIN** Name one element and one relationship you could change in a poster.

# Hierarchy and emphasis

Give the message an intentional reading order.



Emphasis establishes a focal point.

Hierarchy ranks the important information.

Size, placement, weight and contrast work together.

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**TRY · 2 MIN** Predict the first, second and third reading order in each version; then identify the trade-off.

# Balance and proportion

Different parts can carry similar visual weight.

Symmetric



Asymmetric



Symmetry can establish stability.

Asymmetry balances different sizes, values or positions.

Proportion concerns the size of one part relative to another.

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**TRY · 2 MIN** Describe one change that would balance a large subject without duplicating it.

# Contrast

Contrast is a visible difference with a job to do.



Stronger value contrast



Weaker value contrast

Light against dark.

Large against small.

Heavy type against lighter details.

Texture against a quieter area.

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**TRY • 2 MIN** Identify which title is easier to read and explain the specific difference.

# Alignment and proximity

Use shared edges and deliberate gaps to organise information.

## COMMUNITY FILM NIGHT

Friday · 7 pm  
School hall

Tickets at the office

Shared edge; grouped event details

Alignment gives related items a visible structure.

Proximity groups items through distance.

An unrelated item should not appear to belong to the group.

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**TRY · 2 MIN** Sketch a revised notice with one shared edge and two clear information groups.

# Repetition, rhythm, unity and variety

Repeat a useful feature; introduce difference where it carries meaning.



Repeated shape and spacing; one purposeful change

Repetition reconnects related information.

Rhythm creates a visual sequence.

Unity makes the choices feel coherent.

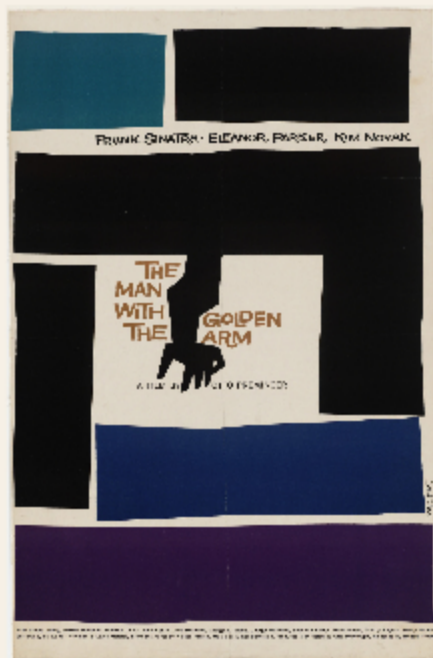
Variety can distinguish an important change.

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**TRY · 2 MIN** Choose one feature to repeat in a poster and one feature that should differ. Explain both jobs.

# Space and visual metaphor

An image can suggest an idea through a carefully chosen form.



Positive space carries the image or type.

Negative space surrounds and separates it.

A metaphor proposes an association; context affects its reading.

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**TRY · 2 MIN** Point to a shape and an empty area. Explain how they affect the image without inventing designer intent.

# Design principles in a real campaign

Recognition can make a small fragment communicate a larger identity.



The arches become directional cues.

Strong contrast supports the cropped symbol.

The treatment depends on prior brand recognition.

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**TRY · 2 MIN** Individual check: identify two principles and one audience limitation.

# Colour models

Name the model before naming the relationship.

|       |                            |
|-------|----------------------------|
| R Y B | Traditional artist's model |
|-------|----------------------------|

R Y B: a traditional artist's hue-wheel model.

|       |                                |
|-------|--------------------------------|
| R G B | Emitted light; digital storage |
|-------|--------------------------------|

R G B: light used by screens and digital image files.

|         |                               |
|---------|-------------------------------|
| C M Y K | Process inks; output workflow |
|---------|-------------------------------|

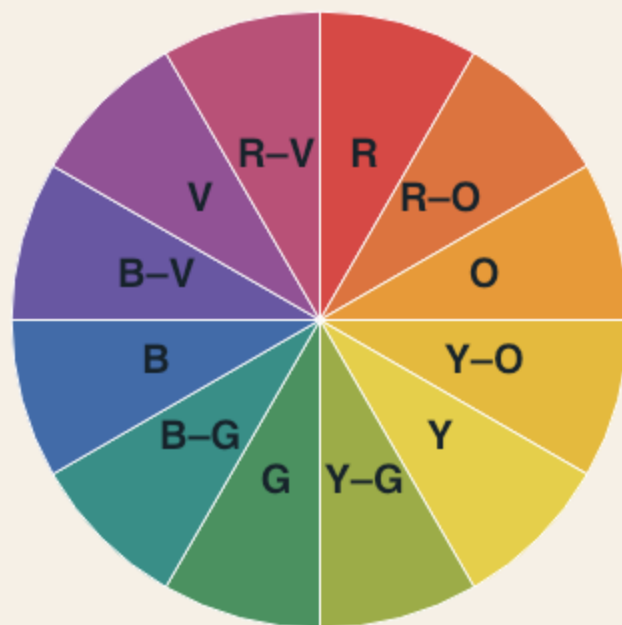
C M Y K: process inks; output depends on the production workflow.

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**TRY • 2 MIN** Which model does our artist's wheel use, and which mode is the screen image stored in?

# The RYB colour wheel

A schematic hue map for comparing relationships.



R red  
O orange  
Y yellow  
G green  
B blue  
V violet

Primary families: red, yellow, blue.

Secondary families: orange, green, violet.

Intermediate families sit between their neighbours.

Equal sectors; RGB samples illustrate RYB hue families

**TRY • 2 MIN** Find an opposite pair and a neighbouring group. Name the model.

# Hue, value and saturation

A useful palette changes more than hue.

Hue



Hue names the colour family.

Value



Value describes lightness or darkness.

Saturation



Saturation describes colour intensity.

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**TRY · 2 MIN** Keep the hue family and change a property that could improve title visibility.

# Palette relationships

Use harmony as a starting point, then test the design.

Complementary



Complementary: opposite hue families.

Analogous



Analogous: neighbouring families.

Triadic



Triadic: three families spaced around the named wheel.

Split complementary



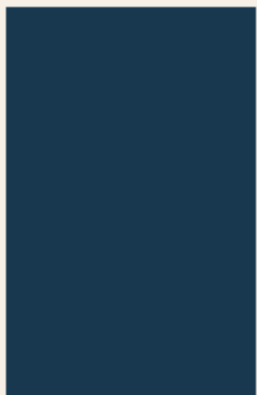
Split complementary: a base and neighbours of its opposite.

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**TRY · 2 MIN** Choose two different starting relationships for one story premise. Explain what you would test.

# Colour roles and proportions

Choose what each colour does in the image.



Dominant  
#18384F



Support  
#8CBAB8



Accent  
#F4B860



Background  
#F6F0E6



Text  
#17232B

Dominant and supporting colours establish the treatment.

An accent directs a limited area of emphasis.

Background and text colours need a readability check.

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**TRY · 2 MIN** Give five colours roles. Name which one you would use least and why.

# Colour meaning needs context

A colour choice is a claim you must examine.



Film genre, culture and neighbouring colours affect interpretation.

A maker's intention and a viewer's response can differ.

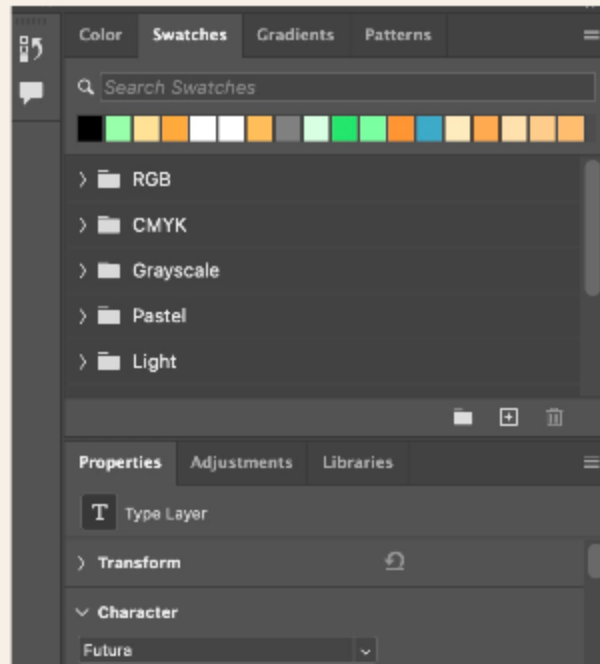
A two-person test gives evidence, not a universal conclusion.

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**TRY • 2 MIN** Separate one visible observation, the documented intention and your interpretation.

# Create and transfer a palette

Use Adobe Color, then carry exact colours into production.



Develop two palette candidates for the same brief.

Record HEX values and assign colour roles.

In Photoshop, open Window → Swatches and add named colours.

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**TRY · 2 MIN** Export or record your five chosen values; apply two to a title/background comparison.

# Typography has communication roles

Choose a voice and a readable information structure.



Typeface: the visual design of the characters.

Weight and size distinguish information roles.

Hierarchy matters before adding extra typefaces.

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**TRY • 2 MIN** Choose a title role and a supporting-information role; explain why they differ.

# Kerning and tracking

One pair and a selected run need different controls.

**AV**

Pair: kerning

**A V**

Kerning changes the gap between a character pair.

Tracking changes spacing across a selected range.

**FILM NIGHT**

Inspect the visible result at the intended size.

**F I L M   N I G H T**

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**TRY · 2 MIN** A gap between A and V is awkward, but the rest of the title is fine. Which control and selection are appropriate?

# Leading and alignment

Manage the lines as well as the letters.

## A story told in two lines

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Baseline → baseline = leading

A shared reading edge  
organises this text.

Leading sets the distance  
between text baselines.

Alignment establishes the shared  
reading edge.

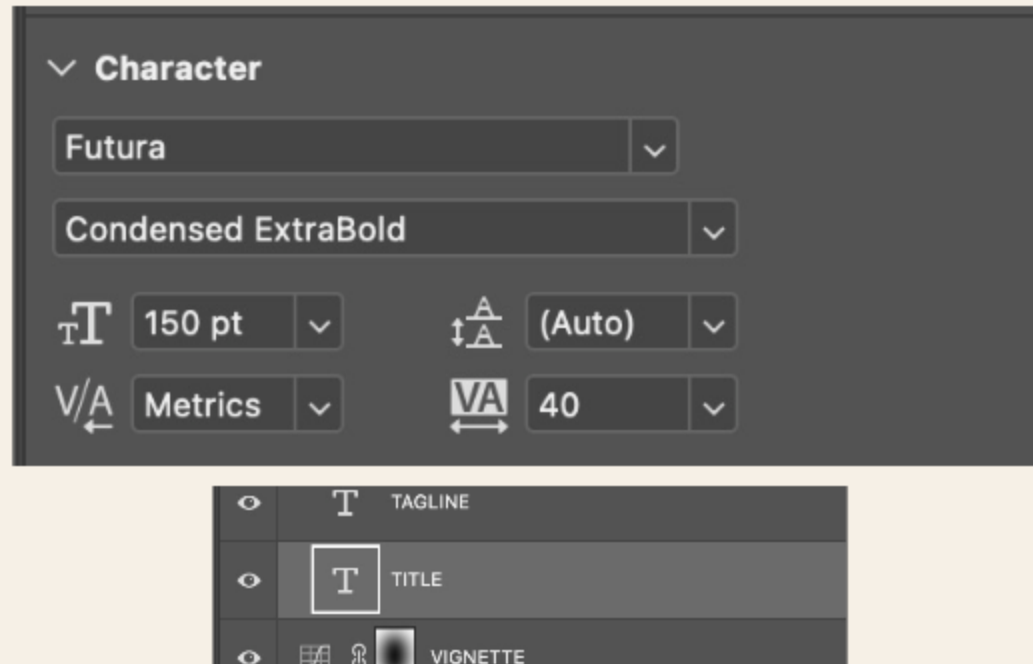
Check line breaks and proximity  
to other information.

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**TRY · 2 MIN** Diagnose the cramped two-line message. Name the control and one thing to keep constant.

# Typography in Photoshop

Match the control to the problem you observed.



Select the Type layer and the relevant text.

Use the Character controls for size, leading, kerning or tracking.

Keep the Type layer editable for the next revision.

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**TRY · 2 MIN** Locate one pair control and one range control in the image. Explain when each is useful.

## A photographic story cue

A24's film still uses colour, light and placement to suggest a story.



Observe the silhouette, light, colour and position.

A24 describes a life moving from childhood to adulthood.

Explain your interpretation using both form and context.

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**TRY • 2 MIN** Write an observation → contextual connection → interpretation, then name a limit.

# Historical and current image analysis

Compare decisions and contexts, not which image you prefer.



Saul Bass • 1955



BILLIE • 2026

Saul Bass: The Man with the Golden Arm, 1955.

BILLIE: Pentagram's promotional identity, 2026.

Compare form, message, viewing context and possible emotional impact.

**TRY • 2 MIN** Individually write one similarity, one difference and one question about cultural or historical context.

# Apply and retrieve

Design two treatments before choosing one.

PLAN

Three distinct alternatives

Three distinct thumbnails for your own premise.

CREATE

Two treatments for one direction

Two colour/type treatments for the selected direction.

JUSTIFY

Audience + purpose + evidence

Choose using audience, purpose and viewing evidence.

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**TRY · 8 MIN** Make your first three thumbnail directions. Below them, state the audience and message in one sentence.